

Top Five Wired Countries

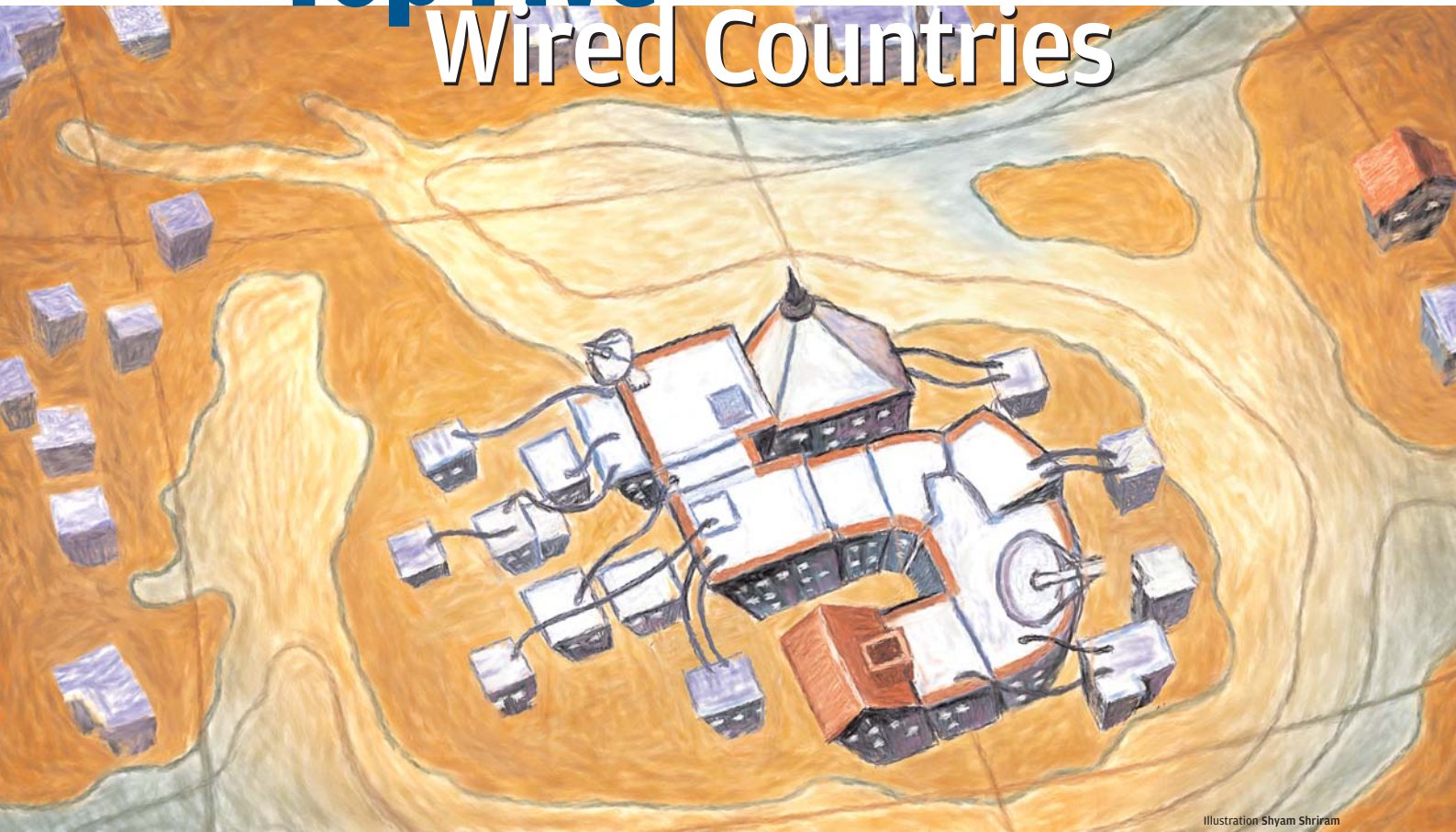


Illustration Shyam Shriram

The top five wired nations are not just about the highest number of PCs or mobile phones. They also have policy support for digitisation and a tech-savvy citizenry

Renuka Rane

Which are the five most-wired nations in the world today? We have shortlisted five countries that are leaders in the wired revolution, with soaring technological innovations and a rapidly multiplying Internet community. We considered various parameters to arrive at the select some.

We took into account the Information Society Index (ISI) 2004—research firm IDC's annual survey, which evaluates the information wealth of 53 countries around the world. It combines 15 variables in four infrastructure pillars (computers, the Internet, telecommunications and social factors) to calculate and rank each nation's ability to access and utilise information and information technology.

We also considered the annual 'E-readiness' rankings for 2004 and 2005, prepared by the Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU) of *The Economist* and IBM's Institute for Business Value. The 65 countries surveyed are assessed on their ability to promote and support digital business and information and communications technology (ICT) services—a weighted collection of nearly 100 quantitative and qualitative criteria.

However, keep in mind the estimates arrived at by the surveys may vary. Also, the rankings accorded to the nations by research firms are very dynamic.

SINGAPORE

A global hub in Asia, Singapore is a kind of bellwether for the introduction of new technology. It ranks first in the Global IT Report 2004-2005. Also, in the 2004 e-readiness rankings by the EIU, Singapore emerged as the top country for Asia-Pacific. The island nation is also the second most wired country in the world, according to the 2004 Networked Readiness Index.

It is strategically located within ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations), which represents a combined market of more than 500 million people. Singapore has the lowest rates of corruption and is ideal to initiate e-commerce and Internet marketing. Singapore is host to more than 6,000 multi-national corporations; the high-tech and financial services industries are lightly regulated, and telecom was privatised in 2000.



Capital: Singapore
Population (millions): 3.54
Area: 683 sq km
Internet penetration: 60.2 % (Sep 04)

Consider Singapore's port: it has a first-mover status as the world's IT leader in seaport logistics. A world leader in broadband rollout, there are thousands of broadband access points across the country.